NSRA Title XL · Sec. 4006 · National Verifiable Voting System

# Elections any citizen can check, from your own phone

Today you are asked to trust the count. Under the NSRA you can check it. Every ballot, from Congress down to school board, is posted in encrypted form to a public ledger as it is counted. You confirm your own ballot was counted with a code. Anyone can verify every total with free software. And no one, not an official, a party, a vendor or a hacker, can see how you voted.

## Why it matters

More than 158 million ballots were cast in 2024 (Election Assistance Commission). A year later, only 60% of Americans were confident that votes in the 2026 midterms would be counted accurately nationwide, and trust had fallen among Democrats, Republicans and independents alike (UC San Diego Yankelovich Center, December 2025 to January 2026). Whoever loses, a large share of the country doubts the result. The fix is not asking people to trust harder. It is letting them check.

## How it works

| Step | What happens |
|---|---|
| **1. You vote on paper** | Mark your ballot by hand or on an accessible device. The paper ballot is the official record. |
| **2. It is scanned and encrypted** | The scanner locks your choices with encryption and gives you a confirmation code. Mail ballots get the same treatment when they arrive. |
| **3. It goes on the public ledger** | Every accepted ballot, still encrypted, is posted to a public ledger anyone can watch from any device, as the count happens. |
| **4. You check your vote** | Enter your code on your phone and see that your ballot is on the ledger and was counted, or why it was not accepted. |
| **5. Anyone checks the totals** | Totals are computed from the encrypted ballots, posted at least hourly with a mathematical proof that anyone can verify with free software. |
| **6. Paper confirms it** | Before certification, states audit the paper ballots against the ledger. If they ever disagree, a hand count of the paper decides. |

## Why it is secure

| Protection | What the bill requires |
|---|---|
| **Offline voting** | No machine that records or counts votes is connected to the internet during voting or counting (Sec. 4006(f)(4)). |
| **Split keys** | The key that unlocks the totals is split among at least five trustees, including one from each major party and an independent. No one can unlock it alone. Individual ballots are never unlocked (Sec. 4006(h)). |
| **Secret ballot** | Your code proves your ballot was counted, never who you voted for, so no one can buy or force your vote (Sec. 4006(i)). |
| **Open source, publicly owned** | The public owns the code, anyone can inspect it, and any manufacturer can build equipment for it, so no county depends on one vendor (Sec. 4006(c)). |
| **Attacked before it is trusted** | Independent hackers test it and a public bug bounty runs before every federal election, and no software changes are allowed in the last 90 days except certified security fixes (Sec. 4006(k)). |
| **Copies everywhere** | The ledger is held by the state, the federal commission and at least two independent archives, so no one can quietly change it (Sec. 4006(g)(5)). |

## States run it. Washington backs it.

| Who | Responsibility |
|---|---|
| **States and localities** | Run every election under a State Verifiable Voting Plan they write. A plan is approved unless the federal commission names a specific requirement it misses within 90 days (Sec. 4006(q)). |
| **States and Washington together** | A State-Federal Council, co-chaired by a state election chief with equal numbers from each party, reviews every standard and software release first. If most of its state and local members object, the commission must answer in writing and wait 90 more days, and no federal standard can override a state's approved plan except on the core security rules (Sec. 4006(l)). |
| **Washington** | Builds and secures the open-source software, tests it, offers free cyber response, and pays most of the cost: 90% of equipment and setup and 75% of operations, the same rates it pays for state Medicaid systems (Sec. 4006(n)). |

This is a partnership, built the way states and the federal government already share Medicaid's computer systems. States and counties keep running their elections: they pick their equipment from certified options, set their own procedures, host their own ledger, and keep sole custody of their voter rolls. No federal official handles or counts a ballot, picks a polling place or certifies a result, and no federal agency gets access to voter rolls or ballots.

Oversight is a joint review every two years. A state that falls short fixes it with a corrective plan of its own design. The only penalties are a smaller federal share and, for congressional races, a court order. No federal officer can take over an election.

## Every ballot, local to national

One ballot usually carries races for Congress, governor, county, city council, school board and ballot measures. The system handles all of them on the same ballot, including multi-seat races, ranked-choice races where a state uses them, write-ins, every language required by the Voting Rights Act, and private, independent voting for people with disabilities. It is required for congressional elections. When a state uses it for every race on the ballot, local included, the federal share covers the whole system.

## Already proven in real elections

This kind of system, called end-to-end verifiable voting, is not theory. Voters in Fulton, Wisconsin used it in 2020, and voters in Franklin County, Idaho used it in the 2022 midterms. The federal voting-system standards adopted in 2021 already allow it. The NSRA builds it once, for the whole country, and gives it to every state for free.

## What about voting from your phone?

You can check your vote from your phone on day one. Casting it from your phone comes later, and only when it is safe. Today the Department of Homeland Security, the FBI, the Election Assistance Commission and NIST rate sending ballots over the internet as high-risk. So the bill starts pilots within three years for military and overseas voters and voters with disabilities, and opens phone voting more widely only after federal security agencies certify it and Congress votes to approve it (Sec. 4006(m)).

## Timeline and cost

| When | What |
|---|---|
| **2 years** | No internet connection on voting equipment; secret-ballot and voter-roll protections in force |
| **3 years** | System certified; pilots for military, overseas and disabled voters begin |
| **Next federal election** | Live in at least five volunteer states, for every race on the ballot |
| **6 years** | Required for every election for Congress |

Washington pays 90% of equipment and setup, up to $10,000 per polling place, and 75% of running it, including audits, poll-worker training and voter education. States write their plans within three years. The money moves through the normal annual budget, so the system adds no automatic spending to the bill.

*Operative text: Title XL, Sec. 4006. Sources: EAC 2024 Election Administration and Voting Survey; UC San Diego Yankelovich Center, Confidence in Elections 2025–2026; EAC Voluntary Voting System Guidelines 2.0 (2021); CISA, EAC, FBI and NIST, Risk Management for Electronic Ballot Delivery, Marking, and Return (2020, reissued 2024); National Academies, Securing the Vote (2018); ElectionGuard pilot reports (2020, 2022).*

*Full text: theamericandeal.org/bill-text · This page: theamericandeal.org/secure-elections · Contact: contact@theamericandeal.org · Fiscal figures are internal models, not CBO or JCT scores. Drafted by Santonio D. Sanders.*